# Heart rhythm problems (arrhythmia)

Heart rhythm problems (arrhythmia) are when your heart beats too quickly or too slowly, or your heartbeat is not steady. It might not be serious but see a GP if you think you're having symptoms.

## Symptoms of heart rhythm problems

There are different types of heart rhythm problem.

You may have a fast heartbeat (tachycardia), a slow heartbeat (bradycardia) or an irregular heartbeat where the rhythm changes.

This can make you feel:

- like your heart is pounding, racing, fluttering or missing a beat (heart palpitations (Link: www.nhs.uk/symptoms/heart-palpitations/)) – this may last for a few seconds up to a few minutes
- short of breath
- lightheaded, dizzy or like you might faint
- tired
- chest pain or discomfort

Having these symptoms does not necessarily mean you have a heart rhythm problem.

### See a GP if:

- you think you may have heart rhythm problems
- you have heart palpitations that keep happening or are getting worse

### Call 999 or go to A&E if:

You currently have heart palpitations with any of these symptoms:

- chest pain
- shortness of breath
- feeling dizzy or lightheaded
- fainting or feeling like you might faint

Find your nearest A&E **(Link: https://www.nhs.uk/service-search/find-an-accident-and-emergency-service/)**

If you've had these symptoms but they've now stopped, ask your GP surgery for an urgent appointment, call 111 or get help from 111 online (Link: https://111.nhs.uk/triage/check-your-symptoms).

Do not drive to A&E. Ask someone to drive you or call 999 and ask for an ambulance.

Bring any medicines you take with you.

## Treatment for heart rhythm problems

How a heart rhythm problem is treated depends on the type you have and what's causing it.

Many people may not need any treatment at all or will only need regular check-ups.

Possible treatments include:

- medicine to control the rate and rhythm of your heartbeat, such as beta blockers (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/beta-blockers/)
- burning or freezing the section of heart that's causing your faulty heart rhythm (ablation)
- using electrical signals to reset your heart rhythm (cardioversion)
- having a small electronic device that helps monitor and correct your heart rhythm fitted under your skin (pacemaker implantation (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/pacemaker-implantation/))

You may also need treatment for any condition that's causing your heart rhythm problems.

## Causes of heart rhythm problems

Heart rhythm problems happen when there's a fault with the electrical system that makes your heart beat.

This can be the result of a heart rhythm condition, such as atrial fibrillation (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/atrial-fibrillation/) or supraventricular tachycardia (SVT) (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/supraventricular-tachycardia-svt/).

Sometimes other conditions can also cause heart rhythm problems, including:

- high blood pressure (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/high-blood-pressure/)
- coronary heart disease (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/coronary-heart-disease/)
- heart valve disease (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/heart-valve-disease/)
- heart attack (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/heart-attack/)
- Wolff-Parkinson-White syndrome (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/wolff-parkinson-white-syndrome/)

You can also get an abnormal heartbeat from:

- medicines
- viruses
- caffeine
- alcohol, smoking or drugs

## Find out more

- British Heart Foundation: arrhythmias (Link: https://www.bhf.org.uk/informationsupport/conditions/arrhythmias)
- Arrhythmia Alliance (Link: https://heartrhythmalliance.org/aa/uk/)

Page last reviewed: 28 October 2024
Next review due: 28 October 2027